

CRAFT Centres - Community Reconstruction and Future Transformation in Gaza

Project title	CRAFT Centres - Community Reconstruction and Future Transformation in Gaza
Focal point	Jacob Sprang – Country Director (Jacob.sprang@acted.org)
Location	Gaza strip
Project duration (dates)	12 months
Overall Objective	Support community-led recovery and reconstruction in Gaza through neighbourhood-level spaces that enable collective planning, climate-smart rebuilding, and inclusive participation.
Target Beneficiaries	100,000 individuals
Total Budget	1,330,000 \$

1. Context in Gaza

The ceasefire in Gaza has opened a fragile window for the population to return to devastated neighbourhoods. More than two million people live amid unprecedented destruction of housing, infrastructure, and social services. While large-scale reconstruction frameworks are yet to emerge, a consistent number of families have already moving back to their neighbourhoods of origin, repairing homes and reconnecting social networks, while others are waiting to return in the absence of available basic services and functioning governance structures.

In this vacuum, recovery must be anchored in the community itself. Gaza's neighbourhoods remain the primary reference point for identity, solidarity, and coordination. Within each neighbourhood, the block (*muraba*) and *hara* provide the living fabric through which families organize daily life, resolve disputes, and deliver mutual aid. These are not just physical divisions - they are the social infrastructure that continues to function even when institutions do not.

To enable communities to rebuild safely, inclusively, and sustainably while integrating social cohesion and collective decision-making, there is a need for light, replicable, and community-driven mechanisms that connect people, technical expertise, and humanitarian and recovery partners.

Since the start of the conflict, community actors and national organizations have been at the forefront of the humanitarian response in Gaza. Despite significant access challenges, local communities have consistently found innovative ways to meet needs and maintain the resilience of the civilian population in Gaza.

It is anticipated that many neighbourhoods will see a mix of returnees, host communities and displaced families, with multiple displacement modalities likely to persist for months or even years.

2. The concept of CRAFT Centres

CRAFT Centres - Community Reconstruction and Future Transformation Centres - respond to this need.

Serving hosting, returning, and displaced populations, CRAFT Centres are neighbourhood-based reconstruction spaces that empower communities to design and coordinate their own recovery. They also act as inclusive community resource and information centres.

Each Centre acts as an accessible, inclusive point where residents, engineers, architects, social entrepreneurs, facilitators, and youth volunteers jointly plan the repair of homes and social infrastructure, develop recovery data, and pilot innovative, climate-smart construction solutions. They are centred around community recovery, economic empowerment and social cohesion while being intentionally light structures - adaptable to different governance scenarios, embedded in existing neighbourhood representation mechanisms, and directly linked to the block and *hara* level where people have historically organized their lives in Gaza.

CRAFT Centres will also help connect community members with humanitarian organizations. Plans developed at these centres can be integrated to improve access to services and support community improvement activities led by site management organizations, while creating entry points for local residents to participate through cash-for-work initiatives. Community-Based Organizations (CBOs), Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) Small and medium enterprises (SMEs), social entrepreneurs and change makers can also use the CRAFT Centres to engage with humanitarian organizations, helping set humanitarian priorities and creating linkages for CBO grants for recovery and reconstruction efforts.

While large-scale reconstruction remains constrained notably by access challenges, the CRAFT Centres are designed as a modular add-on to a broader recovery programme. Ideally, the expansion of the CRAFT Centre model will coincide with a 'progress' scenario where rubble removal, EOD clearance, and the import of construction materials are permitted at scale. They can roll out progressively as conditions allow but will have value even if access conditions remain constrained, as they build on and complement the area-based response which is currently being rolled out in Gaza, providing key entry points for community and civil society actors to shape the response strategy. This model will enhance the protection referral pathways, and mechanisms to support women, youth, persons with disabilities, and vulnerable groups who often face barriers to participating in community decision-making.

Agora in Gaza: Organizing Recovery At Neighborhood Level

Gaza's 192 neighbourhoods (*hayy*) are subdivided into *murabaat* (blocks) and *haras* (sub-blocks). The *hara* is the essential social unit, gathering extended families on inherited land with strong kinship and mutual-support ties. In the absence of functioning government, the block and *hara* remain the legitimate spaces through which communities make collective decisions, maintain social order, and coordinate self-help initiatives. Building recovery around these existing structures ensures legitimacy, community ownership, and inclusion. It enables humanitarian and reconstruction actors to work with - not around - the social geography that people already trust, while integrating returnees, host communities and displaced populations.

Acted is working through territorial approaches aligned with these administrative areas in both its emergency and early recovery planning. Acted's area-based site management approach focuses on responding to all displacement modalities at block level, complementing Agora programming for recovery at the Neighborhood level. The CRAFT Centre model will look to align with this territorial approach, with one CRAFT Centre per neighborhood targeted through Acted's Agora programming. In areas where Acted is in the process of setting up Community Resource Centres (CRC) through its Site Management programming, CRAFT Centres can be a natural evolution for these facilities. During the emergency phase, CRAFT Centres can serve as areas of collaboration for international organizations to engage with CBOs, CSOs and national NGOs operating in the area. Partnerships to support ongoing efforts can be developed through the Centres, helping identify community-level priorities and initiatives which can be supported by humanitarian actors. As the context shifts towards early recovery and reconstruction phases, the Craft Centres will transition to inclusive points for joint recovery planning between communities and humanitarian actors. After reconstruction, as the context transitions to post-conflict, the Centres can serve as entry points for humanitarian actors to continue to support communities through social development programming, cultural activities, and more development-focused activities.

3. Objectives and expected results

Overall Objective

Support community-led recovery and reconstruction in Gaza through neighbourhood-level spaces that enable collective planning, climate-smart rebuilding, and inclusive participation.

Specific Objectives

1. Facilitate safe and dignified returns, the integration of displaced populations by supporting them in identifying priorities for housing and infrastructure repairs together with host communities;
2. Enhance community-based data systems and accountability mechanisms to support evidence-informed recovery planning, transparent decision-making, and responsive service delivery.
3. Support the engagement of youth and women in decision making for reconstruction;
4. Strengthen self-organization and coordination of community recovery efforts at neighbourhood, block, and *hara* levels;
5. Maintain and enhance the two-way communication humanitarian organizations with communities, CBOs and CSOs to promote community ownership;
6. Produce reliable, community-generated data to inform wider recovery planning;
7. Promote innovation and sustainable construction practices adapted to Gaza's constraints.

Expected Results

Outcome

- # CRAFT Centres established across heavily affected neighbourhoods;
- # of recovery plans developed at CRAFT Centers and implemented within the affected neighbourhoods;
- # households engaged in participatory recovery planning;
- # locally developed innovation prototypes piloted through monthly innovation challenges, supported with seed funding or in-kind assistance (e.g., solar micro-solutions, debris-recycling tools, low-tech repair devices);
- # community groups, CBOs/CSOs, and local SMEs receiving mentoring and demonstrating increased capacity in community-driven innovation and participatory recovery methods.

Output

- Neighbourhood-level recovery data shared with humanitarian and recovery coordination mechanisms;
- Demonstration of climate-smart construction techniques, including the use of Interlocking Stabilized Soil Blocks (ISSB), Compressed Earth Blocks (CEB) or Rubble-Recycling Concrete (RRC).

4. Key components of the CRAFT Centres

Participatory reconstruction design spaces

Each CRAFT Centre provides an open, community-friendly environment where residents can meet trained personnel from partnered CBOs, CSOs, SMEs, such as architects, social entrepreneurs, engineers, change makers and facilitators, to jointly plan the repair or rebuilding of homes, schools, clinics, and other essential facilities. The space operates as a **small neighborhood reconstruction centre**, where technical advice can be given to families looking to rebuild or repair their homes. For rehabilitation of communal goods (including roads, public facilities, schools), proposed interventions can be referred to humanitarian actors supporting community-led initiatives and community-driven recovery plans in close coordination with relevant stakeholders. Trainings and information on risks, such as those posed by EOD/UXOs, during reconstruction

efforts can be provided through the Centres, to ensure that residents understand and can mitigate against these risks.

If the access environment improves, and entry of machinery necessary to scale up reconstruction efforts becomes feasible, each Centre can become a hub for information on sustainable and climate-smart building techniques. Approaches like the Interlocking Stabilized Soil Blocks (ISSB) which were tested in Gaza by UNRWA and other agencies, can be presented as green innovative options to residents working on rebuilding their homes. Residents who choose to adopt this measure, if convinced by its advantages (reduced cement use (~30%), affordability, and thermal efficiency), can be provided technical guidance on the process. Organizations supporting reconstruction – either through climate-smart building techniques, like the ISSB, or more traditional methods, can provide training sessions and technical support to local community members. Organizations implementing livelihoods activities related to the reconstruction efforts, including temporary cash for work schemes and longer-term grants and business support, can use the CRAFT Centres as entry points in identifying program participants and in leading community consultations. Through these hands-on activities, the Centres make reconstruction tangible and inclusive, translating technical guidance into action at household and block level.

Community data and digital mapping labs

Each Centre can host a small digital workspace to support recovery needs analysis at neighbourhood level. Using this workspace, IMPACT Initiatives - a leading applied research organization and the largest independent provider of data in crisis-affected contexts - will support the co-development of area-based assessment tools and lead targeted data collection. Findings will be brought back into the Centres through participatory analysis and recovery planning workshops, facilitated by IMPACT and Acted, where community members, CBOs, and CSOs jointly review evidence, validate priorities against lived experience, and organize recovery needs at block and hara level. Through this process, communities progressively build the ability to structure needs reviews, engage with evidence, and translate analysis into neighbourhood recovery plans, strengthening ownership and reinforcing coordination with Site Management and AGORA programming.

As the context shifts more into early recovery and reconstruction, and access improves, the CRAFT Centres can evolve to support these processes. The digital workspace can integrate open-source GIS tools such as OpenStreetMap and train Community Data Fellows on how to use these tools. Fellows can then help collect information on housing damage, access to basic services, and community priorities. They map the neighbourhood's blocks and *haras*, producing simple visual dashboards that are displayed publicly in the Centre. This evidence allows residents to identify the most impacted areas requiring targeted reconstruction support and access to basic services, while it helps organizing the coordination of assistance across blocks. The data will also be shared with humanitarian and recovery partners to coordinate and guide decisions, avoid duplication, and ensure equitable coverage. In practice, the data labs turn local knowledge into a community-owned recovery monitoring system that strengthens accountability and transparency.

The Centres will leverage existing socio-spatial baseline data already developed by Acted and IMPACT, including mapping of blocks, haras, displacement sites, and demographic profiles. Community Data Fellows will update this baseline in real time, ensuring that partners can access dynamic information for planning and targeting.

Innovation and livelihood corners

Each CRAFT Centre functions as a small incubator for local innovation. During the emergency phase, locally

driven solutions to meeting community needs can be identified through the Centres and referred to site management actors to oversee the implementation of these solutions as community-led initiatives. As the context shifts further into the recovery phase, the Craft Centres can adopt more structured approaches to fostering local innovation. Every month, the Centres can organize Innovation Challenges such as Hackathons, inviting young people, artisans, and community groups to pitch practical ideas for neighbourhood recovery - ranging from small solar energy solutions and debris recycling to low-tech repair tools or digital applications for reconstruction tracking. Winners can receive modest seed funding or in-kind support together with mentoring from local experts from humanitarian organizations, CBOs, CSOs, SMEs, social entrepreneurs, change makers or other public service providers, enabling them to pilot their ideas locally. The Centres can also loan simple production equipment such as block presses or hand tools to help entrepreneurs test prototypes or start micro-enterprises. This combination of creativity, competition, and tangible support channels the energy of Gaza's youth into visible recovery actions and strengthens local ownership of the rebuilding process.

In addition to supporting youth and entrepreneurs, the Centres will also train local NGOs, SMEs, social entrepreneurs, change makers and community-based organizations in participatory recovery methods, digital mapping, and community engagement, expanding local institutional capacity for future reconstruction using Acted's signature CATALYST (Capacity Assessment, Technical Assistance, and Learning for Sustainable Transformation) approach to building organizational, entrepreneurial and institutional capacity, building on evolving partnerships developed during the emergency phase.

Community information and coordination interfaces

Each Centre will also function as an emergency-focused information and service access point. During the initial emergency phase, the Centres can serve as help desks, where humanitarian staff can provide information and receive feedback from communities to promote two-way communication. Over time, as access improves and the context shifts towards the recovery and reconstruction phase, this function can be scaled up. Noticeboards, digital kiosks, and community facilitators will provide up-to-date guidance on where, when, and how residents - both displaced and returning - can access humanitarian assistance, shelter repair materials, health, and protection services. Regular "recovery and service forums" will bring together community representatives to identify urgent needs, coordinate outreach, and ensure the most vulnerable households are not left behind. These forums can feed into the existing community engagement activities of the site management and Agora teams.

5. Implementation strategy and partnerships

Scale and Duration

A 12-month pilot phase will establish 1 CRAFT Centre covering an area. The model is designed for rapid replication once access and funding expand.

Implementation Approach

- Centres are hosted in existing community resource centres established by Acted's site management team and will be managed by trained community facilitators and local technical staff, identified by the site management team with support from Acted's Agora team through a structured and proven process.
- Activities will dovetail with the local engagement strategy currently being developed by the Gaza team, ensuring coherence with both the site management response and the neighbourhood-level area-based response pilot.

- CRAFT Centres will integrate age, gender and diversity -sensitive participation, ensuring that women and youth play visible roles in recovery planning and innovation through a community-based approach while also identifying any protection related aspects.

Partnerships

- CRAFT Centres will use Acted's global CATALYST tools for CBOs and Enterprise Capacity Assessment Toolkit (ECAT) – for engaging with and supporting civil society organizations, community-based organizations, SMEs, social entrepreneurs and change makers. In partnership with the Palestinian NGO Network (PNGO), Acted will identify and partner with key national NGO and CBO partners in target areas to support the development and implementation of activities at the CRAFT Centres. Resources to support the work of these partner organizations can be provided through the CRAFT Centre.
- The Centres will link to these local structures to existing coordination platforms such as the Area-Based Coordination (ABC) system, ICCG and humanitarian clusters – including Site Management Cluster, food security, shelter, WASH, livelihoods, and protection.
- Technical support and data management will draw on partnerships with academic and technical institutions, as well as international organizations supporting digital mapping and reconstruction analytics (e.g. IMPACT) when contextual conditions allow it.

Scalability and Sustainability

- CRAFT Centres are locally accessible platforms that demonstrate how community-driven recovery can bridge humanitarian assistance and mid-term reconstruction.
- By anchoring reconstruction in the neighborhood and block level, they will reinforce existing Agora and site management programming both during the initial emergency phase throughout the recovery and reconstruction process.
- Once a post-conflict stage is reached, the CRAFT Centres can provide key entry points for Acted and other humanitarian actors to continue to engage with communities and shift to longer-term programming, including livelihoods activities, programming that supports cultural and civic life, and green programming.

6. Added value and wider impact

CRAFT Centres bring unique value to Gaza's recovery by translating large-scale reconstruction objectives into community-led, inclusive, and stabilizing action. These Centres build on the existing efforts that Acted has made through its site management and Agora programming during the last two years of emergency response.

First, they channel the energy and aspirations of Gaza's youth into supporting the emergency response while constructively building skills for their future. In a context where frustration and marginalization can fuel despair or negative coping mechanisms, the Centres offer meaningful engagement and purpose – enabling change makers and young people to contribute directly to meeting the needs of their community, helping rebuild their neighbourhoods, acquire technical and digital skills, and see tangible results from their efforts.

Second, the Centres restore agency and social cohesion at a time of deep institutional uncertainty. By organizing reconstruction around the familiar structures of neighborhoods and blocks, they strengthen community solidarity and empower residents to make joint decisions on priorities and resource allocation.

Third, CRAFT Centres promote innovation and local resilience. By promoting climate-smart reconstruction methods and neighbourhood-scale energy or recycling solutions, they demonstrate how Gaza's recovery can be both environmentally sustainable and economically inclusive.

Finally, the model bridges humanitarian and reconstruction phases, providing an operational framework that can adapt to any future governance scenario. CRAFT Centres build on the existing work of Acted's site management and Agora programming. Over time, the Centres will help develop a locally legitimate, data-informed foundation that international and national recovery actors can scale once access, materials, and political conditions allow.

In short, CRAFT Centres combine social stabilization, youth and women engagement, and green reconstruction - demonstrating how Gaza's recovery can start from within its neighbourhoods, by and for its communities.